

The Kind of Problem Poverty Is

POSC 459 — Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Week 2 · Monday, August 31

Desmond, Poverty, by America, chapter 1

Today

1. **Twenty minutes of writing** — the baseline diagnostic
2. Then chapter 1, together

Wednesday: bring a laptop or a phone. The research pre-survey and PapyrusAI sign-up both happen in the room.

Why the writing comes first

So that you and I both know what your thinking sounds like on the page — in your own voice, at the start of the semester.

- Not graded for content. Participation credit.
- Handwritten, about 20 minutes. **No AI, no devices.**
- A reference sample, not a trust test. In December, this page is how you and I will both see how your own reasoning developed.

The prompt

Last Monday, the board filled with your answers to one question: *what do you think of when you hear the term "poor"?*

A week in: **what kind of problem is poverty?** Take a position and support it with two specifics from anywhere in the course so far — the Rank chapters, Desmond's chapter 1, Part 1 of the film, last week's discussion, or the board itself.

Close with a sentence or two: has anything from this first week shifted how you would define poverty? *"No, and here's why"* is a fine answer.

About 20 minutes. Handwritten. No hidden checklist — use what you've actually read, watched, or heard. Not graded for content: honest beats polished. Hand it in when you finish.

Last Monday, your board

Sixteen answers. Causes and conditions — an economy, a zip code, a policing pattern, debt.

Not one person on it.

Desmond spends chapter 1 on what the board left out: **what the problem does to a person.**

So: what does the chapter see that the board could not?

The official answer is a line

- 1965: Mollie Orshansky, a bureaucrat at the Social Security Administration.
- A bare-bones food budget was about a third of a family's spending — so: **cheap food budget × 3 = the poverty line.**
- Updated for inflation and nothing else, ever since.
- 2026: **\$15,960** for one person · **\$33,000** for a family of four.

Plenty of poverty above the line

- What do you call raising two kids on \$50,000 in Miami?
- Or here: in Orange County, the official "low income" line for a family of four is **\$148,850** (2026) — four and a half times the poverty line.
- Rent takes half the paycheck; student loans take a quarter.
- Income volatility — paychecks swinging month to month — has **doubled since 1970**.
- Below the line one month, just above it the next, never steady.

Crystal

- Born premature, the day her mother was stabbed. Foster care at five. **Twenty-five placements** by eighteen.
- At eighteen: SSI, **\$754 a month**. "SSI always come."
- The adult reevaluation said otherwise. Then shelters, streets, survival.

The knot

Desmond's image for poverty as it is lived: several hardships tangled together, each pulling the others tighter, while the line measures only income.

- **Pain** — two amputations a week in America's meatpacking plants; free-Advil vending machines in the warehouse.
- **Instability** — 3.6 million eviction filings in an average year.
- **Fear** — half of all new jobs gone within a year; wages wobbly week to week.
- **Lost liberty** — almost 2 million people in prison and jail today, uncounted by the poverty statistics.
- **Shame** — "poverty felt morally." There is no flag for poor rights.
- **The bandwidth tax** — scarcity takes more mind than a full night without sleep.

The knot has faces you've met

Growing Up Poor in America, Part 1 — three Ohio families, assigned last week

- **Kyah, 14, Columbus** — a year without a home; blankets laid out each night into "a little twin-size bed."
"I don't think I should have to carry these worries as a kid, but I just choose to."
- **Fantasy, Marietta** — gas station wages: *"Some weeks I'm paycheck to paycheck. Most weeks I'm paycheck till the next day."*
- **Crystal, The Plains** — *"What I get is \$485 per month and I get approximately \$400 in food stamp assistance. So I take \$885 times 12 equals \$10,620 for three."* The 2020 poverty line for three: about \$20,600.

And far below the line

- Deep poverty: **half** the poverty line — \$7,980 for one person, \$16,500 for a family of four (2026).
- **One in twenty** Americans — 16.8 million people (2024). Children fare worst: **6.2 percent**, about 4.5 million, a larger share than any adult age group.
- Angus Deaton, 2018: 5.3 million Americans poor "**by global standards**" — living on \$4 a day or less.
 - The standard: the World Bank's global destitution line — \$1.90 a day at the time — adjusted up to about \$4 for what bare survival costs in a rich country.

Poverty is no equalizer

- There is **no U.S. metro area** where poor white families are concentrated in neighborhoods with poverty above 40 percent. Many poor Black and Hispanic families live exactly there (Desmond, ch. 1).
- Median household wealth, 2022: **\$285,000** white · **\$61,600** Hispanic · **\$44,900** Black (Federal Reserve, Survey of Consumer Finances).
- Roughly six white dollars for every Black one — and the dollar gap grew even as every group's median rose.
- Same poverty line. Different poverty.

"Poverty isn't a line. It's a tight knot of social maladies."

— Desmond, chapter 1

If he's right, what would progress even look like?

- If poverty is a line, progress is easy to see: fewer people below it each year.
- If poverty is a knot, a family's income can clear the line while the knot stays tied — the statistic improves, the life doesn't.
- Wednesday's reading takes up exactly that. Chapter 2's title: **"Why Haven't We Made More Progress?"**

Hold the question for 48 hours.

Wednesday

- **Bring a laptop or a phone.** Research pre-survey (~10 min, voluntary, part of a study), then PapyrusAI sign-up, in the room.
- Reading: Howard ch. 2, "Tracks of My Tiers" · Desmond ch. 2.
- And my AI policy goes on the table — as a policy, for critique.